



Education Support Staff · Session 4

Learning Design

Students come first

Move from understanding to design without turning students into a list of problems.

Start with the real students you have in mind, a specific access question and evidence from your school-day map and audit. The design response comes after understanding.

Scaffold, don't substitute

Every support sits somewhere on a ladder towards independence.

Doing for

The adult does the task.

Helping

The adult does part of it with the student.

Prompting

The adult gives a cue, and the student does it.

Coaching

The adult checks in from a distance.

On their own

The student does it on their own.

The aim is for the student to need a little less support over time. Plan the fading.

How this session runs

Short inputs, then doing. You design one step up the ladder for a support you give.

1

Start

10 min · One input, then move

2

Brief

6 min · On your own, with your trio

3

Options

14 min · Input, then choose

4

Universal first

7 min · Trios

5

Design

12 min · On your own, with your trio

6

Check

6 min · On your own, private

7

Continuum

7 min · Input

8

Gallery and commit

9 min · Whole room

You will leave with one support moved a step towards independence.

Regroup

Bring back your Carry into design card from Session 3.

Move to the corner of the room for where your support happens:

In class

Between settings

Breaks and play

Form a trio with two people near you. Each of you keeps your own two or three students in mind.

5 minutes

Keep your students in view

Hold a concise picture of each of the students you have in mind, including:

**Strengths, interests
and joy**

**Communication,
sensory experience
and thinking**

**What costs and what
lightens**

Identity and belonging

**What students,
families and the team
already know**

**Questions that remain
open**

You are not building a file on one student. Keep real, different students in view as you design.

Write your brief

Choose one support moment you give. Your trio helps you sharpen the brief.

At the moment, I support by...

The student can already...

One step more independence would look like...

Check the wording: is it specific, workable and free from blame or deficit labels?

Options menu

Four short inputs. Listen for what might answer your brief.

1

Five moves that belong to you

Small moves you can use in any setting

2

Predictability

Clear information about routine and change

3

Designed distance

Near enough to help, far enough to let peers in

4

Visual supports and social stories

Tools that build understanding and independence

Printed option cards are on your table. After the inputs, choose one or two for your support.

Five moves that belong to you

Small moves you can use in any setting, alongside the teacher's plan:

Give a two-minute warning before a change

Use fewer words when stress appears

Make the first step of a task visible

Write a short note of what you saw, and pass it on

The fifth move, designed distance, has its own input shortly.

Predictability

Predictability includes clear information about routine and change.

Help students answer:



**What is
happening?**



**What is
changing?**



**What comes
next?**



**What can I do if
the plan
changes?**

Give information early enough to be useful.

Designed distance

Where you stand affects how the student, peers and teacher work together.

Staying very close all the time can crowd out peers, the teacher and the student's own first try. Stay near enough to help and far enough that peers and the teacher stay in the picture. Set up the pair work, then step back.



Image placeholder

Try it: pick one lesson where, with the teacher's agreement, you could stand a little further back and notice what changes.

Visual supports and social stories

1  Read your news aloud to the class.	2  Write your news in your book.	3  Draw a picture to match your news.
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Visual Supports Checklist

Online webinar available to explore visual supports in greater depth.

A visual support should clarify something the student needs to find, understand, remember or communicate.

Keep it available at the point of use, avoid unnecessary detail, explain how it works and check its meaning and usefulness with the student.

Quick review of a support

- Does it help the student, or help the student look typical?
- Was it made with the student?
- Does it match what is actually happening?
- Could the student use it without you?

Choose your options

Which one or two options answer your brief?

☐

Five moves that belong to you

Small moves you can use in any setting

☐

Predictability

Clear information about routine and change

☐

Designed distance

Near enough to help, far enough to let peers in

☐

Visual supports and social stories

Tools that build understanding and independence

Write down why the option fits: which step up the ladder does it help?

Record your choice, and why, on your A3 sheet, section 2.

Universal Design for Learning

Apply a Universal Design for Learning lens to the emerging design:

- Make important information clear and available
- Offer workable ways to participate and respond
- Support engagement without removing meaningful challenge

The teacher plans adjustments and you help deliver them.

Design Multiple Means of
Engagement →



Design Multiple Means of
Representation →



Design Multiple Means of
Action & Expression →



Accessibility check

Run these over your draft design, then test it through use and feedback.

☐ Can students find and understand what they need?

☐ Can they take part in more than one way?

☐ Can they pause, ask for help or recover?

☐ Is the support available when demand increases?

One step up the ladder

Plan it on your A3 sheet, section 4.

- 1 One way to fade support, starting next week.
- 2 One communication tool to practise this term.
- 3 One conversation to have with the teacher.
- 4 Decide what you will observe.
- 5 Set a time to review.

Ask your trio to check the design remains student-centred.

Check the design against your students

On your own card, test your plan against each of your students.

	Helps	No difference	Needs something more
Student A			
Student B			
Student C			

Where the design still doesn't work for someone, that is where targeted or individual support begins.

Continuum of support

Support is a continuum rather than a single intervention.

1

Inclusive environment

First, design inclusive environments that reduce barriers for everyone.

2

Universal supports

Then, provide universal supports that many students may benefit from.

3

Targeted supports

Next, offer targeted supports for students who need additional assistance.

4

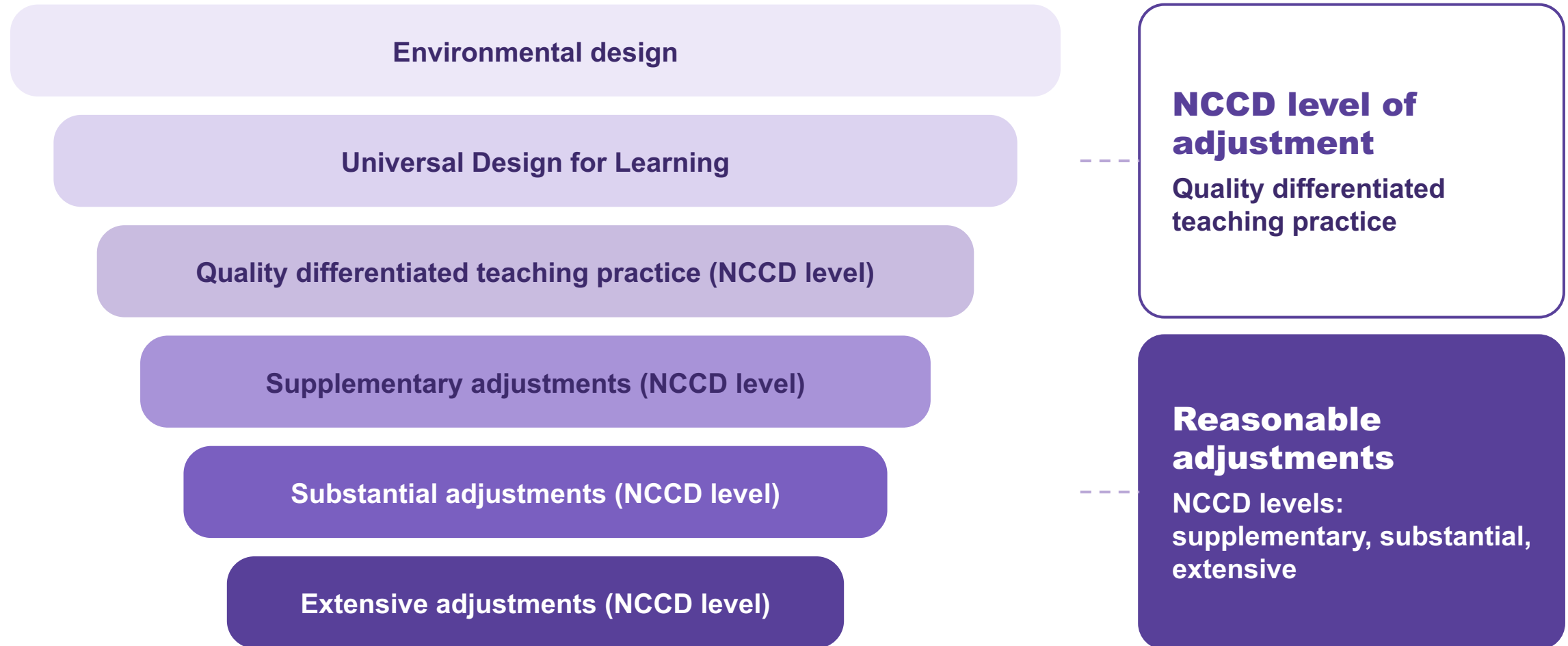
Individual adjustments

Finally, where necessary, implement individual adjustments to ensure equitable access, participation and learning.

Academic adjustments sit within a wider continuum of support.

Consider what is available to everyone, what is targeted and what is individually adjusted. Each response should connect to access and participation needs and be reviewed through use and feedback.

Reasonable adjustments



NCCD

NCCD information and links

Connect the NCCD discussion with reasonable adjustments and evidence. Follow the consultation, documentation and review processes used in your school or system. The teacher and school decide on adjustments. Your observations of how they are working are part of the evidence.



NCCD

NATIONALLY CONSISTENT COLLECTION OF DATA
ON SCHOOL STUDENTS WITH DISABILITY

Gallery walk

See what others have planned.

- 1 Put your A3 design on the wall.
- 2 Walk the gallery. On someone else's plan, leave a Post-it: one idea you would borrow, or one question.
- 3 Return to your own design and read what others left.

9 minutes, with commit

Share, refine and commit



After the gallery, ask yourself:

- What support will you fade first?
- What will you notice?
- What will you talk to the teacher about?
- How will the student's view be included, with the teacher?

Treat the change as something to try, review and refine.